

knocking out Ian Nepomniachtchi in the World Cup. That also meant four Indians were in the quarterfinals and not a single Russian!

Vidit booked his Candidates berth in style. He won the prestigious 2023 FIDE Grand Swiss — the strongest Open tournament of the year — despite being the 15th seed.

In a strong field with 114 players from 37 countries, Vidit scored 8.5 points to finish half a point ahead of second seed Hikaru Nakamura. To put things into perspective, it is pertinent to recall that 16th seed Arjun Erigaisi finished fourth (7.5 points), top seed Caruana (7) was 10th, eighth seed Praggnanandhaa (7) was 13th and fifth seed Gukesh (5) ended up a distant 81st!

The timely success also underlined Vidit's capabilities of excelling in strong fields and more importantly, his maturity to handle

pressure. After starting with a defeat to Dutch Erwin L'Ami, Vidit won thrice on the trot, drew the next two and won twice to reach 5.5 from seven rounds.

He then drew with Nakamura and Andrey Esipenko before finishing off with victories over Bodgan-Daniel Deac and Alexandr Predke to cap the tournament of his life. Interestingly, during his campaign, the only higher seed Vidit faced was Nakamura.

Overall, Vidit's percentage of wins is way over his losses, with nearly 50 per cent of his games ending in draws. Though he had a forgettable Prague Masters recently where he stayed winless, drawing six and losing three in a row, Vidit is expected to use this as a wake-up call for Toronto.

A fine ambassador of Indian chess and widely followed on social media platforms, 29-year-old Vidit will be

keen to make a show of this opportunity. He has the game, experience and the skill set to make his presence felt. A perpetual underdog without much pressure of expectations, trust Vidit to spring a surprise or two.

K. Humpy: What can be said about the most experienced player in the fray! She has been India's signature in women's chess for nearly two decades. She is not only the 2011 World Championship runner-up but also the 2019 World rapid champion! That shows she has the game to deal with any challenge on a chess board. And this format is just right for the 36-year-old to prove she is ready to add the World crown that is missing from her collection.

As the third seed, Humpy is among the six players who've retained their Candidates spots from the previous edition, held in a

Women

Head-to-head record in Classical games (women)

Only decisive games. Drawn games not considered. DNP denotes Did Not Play



Players	Gor	Tin	Hum	Lag	Zho	Muz	Vai	Sal
Aleksandra Goryachkina (FIDE)	--	1-1	0-1	2-0	3-4	1-1	0-0	1-0
Lei Tingjie (CHINA)	1-1	--	0-4	0-2	5-6	1-0	0-0	0-0
K.Humpy (INDIA)	1-0	4-0	--	3-1	4-0	4-5	0-0	DNP
Kateryna Lagno (FIDE)	0-2	2-0	1-3	--	4-3	1-3	1-0	DNP
Tan Zhongyi (CHINA)	4-3	6-5	0-4	3-4	--	6-3	1-1	DNP
Anna Muzychuk (UKRAINE)	1-1	0-1	5-4	3-1	3-6	--	0-0	1-1
R. Vaishali (INDIA)	0-0	0-0	0-0	0-1	1-1	0-0	--	0-0
Nurgyul Salimovav (Bulgaria)	0-1	0-0	DNP	DNP	DNP	1-1	0-0	--